THE RIGHT TO REFUSE

Women increasingly recognise consent as a right, yet social expectations, emotional coercion and moral judgement still silence choice when it matters most

Illustrations by **NILANJAN DAS** / AI

Consent is usually imagined as a single word spoken at a single moment. This section of the survey examines a more complex idea—that consent is not a one-time 'yes', but a continuing act of agency. It includes the right to refuse, the right to desire and the right to change one's mind, and it is often in love and intimacy that these rights face the greatest pressure. The questions probe the space between choice and pressure, where affection, expectation and guilt blur the line.

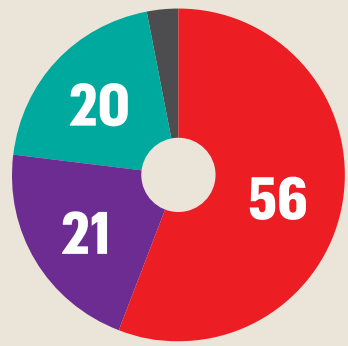
The findings reveal a country that has mastered the principle and struggles with the practice. An overwhelming 79 per cent of women agree that 'no means no' under all circumstances. But only 56 per cent say they can directly refuse something they do not want, 41 per cent soften their refusal with excuses or go along anyway. And just 36 per cent clearly say that consent extracted under pressure is not consent at all; a clear majority still treats pressured agreement as agreement.

The deeper the survey goes into intimacy, the wider the gap grows. Only 36 per cent believe consent in an intimate situation must be explicitly stated, the rest rely on hints, habit or the absence of resistance. When women do not want sexual activity, 51 per cent clearly say 'no', while the others negotiate around it through excuses, discomfort or regret. The right to withdraw is weakest of all: only 36 per cent say a change of mind after initial consent is respected, and just 28 per cent say a woman who withdraws mid-situation is viewed as reasonable. Most say she is seen as confusing, manipulative or dramatic.

What blocks refusal is rarely force. It is the emotional economy that surrounds a woman's 'no'. Seventy-nine per cent feel at least sometimes expected to explain and justify their refusal, and when women stayed silent after discomfort, the most common reason—cited by 43 per cent—was wanting to keep the peace. Three-fourths say society labels assertive women as difficult, arrogant or 'too modern'.

The double standard completes the trap. Sixty-one per cent say a woman who openly expresses her sexual needs is seen as 'not of good character'. If saying 'no' invites anger and saying 'yes' invites judgement, women lose on both sides of the conversation. This section establishes the survey's central insight: the vocabulary of consent has arrived in India, but the social permission to live by it has not. ■

Q. How comfortable are you personally with saying 'no' when you don't want to do something?



- I directly say 'no'
- I struggle to say 'no' and often give indirect excuses
- I usually go along rather than refuse, even if I want to say 'no'
- Rest, DK/ CS

DK/ CS: Don't know/ can't say; all figures in %